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PSYC100

Selective attention

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: Selective attention.

I'm getting your personalized lesson ready — based on what you've learned, what's next, and the best way for you to practice.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Imagine you’re watching a basketball video and I tell you: “Count how many times the players in white pass the ball.” 🏀

Most people feel sure they could still notice anything unusual happening in the scene — even while counting.

Gut check for you, Ron:

If something really obvious and weird walked through that scene (like a person in a gorilla suit), do you think you would definitely notice it while you’re busy counting passes — yes or no?

Maybe not

Nice honest answer — that “maybe” is exactly what this lesson is about. 👀

I’ve just loaded a short video called “Selective attention test.”

Watch it all the way through.
Follow the instructions in the video (don’t skip ahead).
When you’re done, tell me:

Did you notice anything strange in the video, or did it look totally normal to you?

well i definately saw the gorilla but as youd mentioned it i was exectng to see one

That makes sense — because I “primed” you, your attention was partly on “watch for a gorilla,” not just on counting. 🦍

What this video shows in most people (when they aren’t warned) is inattentional blindness:

Inattentional blindness = when you fail to see something that is clearly in front of

you, because your attention is busy with another task.

So the eyes get the image, but attention is “locked onto” the passes, and the gorilla never makes it into awareness.

Quick check before we go deeper:

Does this difference make sense so far?

Perception (eyes): The gorilla is on the screen.
Attention (mind spotlight): If your spotlight is on counting passes, you might not become aware of the gorilla at all.

☑ / **?**

Tell me: does that “spotlight” idea of attention vs. just seeing feel clear enough, or should I go over it with a simple diagram-style explanation?

It's clear

What do you think caused people to miss the gorilla in that experiment? 👇

In the Invisible Gorilla experiment, why do many people completely miss the gorilla walking through the scene?

A.

Because their eyesight temporarily stops working while they count the passes

B.

Because their attention is focused on counting passes, so they don’t process the unexpected gorilla

C.

Because the gorilla costume is camouflaged and almost invisible on the video

D.

Because people already know there won’t be anything unusual, so they ignore the whole video

Exactly right. 🎯

They see the whole scene with their eyes, but their attention is locked onto counting passes, so the brain doesn’t fully process the unexpected gorilla. That’s inattentional blindness in action: when attention is busy, even something big and weird can slip past awareness.

Now let’s bring this into real life:

Imagine a driver turning left while carefully watching for cars — but not really for motorcycles.

Do you think this driver could miss a clearly visible motorcycle, for the same basic reason people miss the gorilla — yes or no?

Yes, I think so

Exactly — that’s the same basic mechanism. 🚗🏍

Step by step, here’s what’s going on in both cases:

Task goal steals the spotlight

Video: “Count the passes by the white team.”
Driving: “Watch for oncoming cars so I can turn.”
Selective attention filters the scene

Your brain gives priority to what matches the goal (passes / cars).
Other things (gorilla / motorcycle) are on the screen or in the road, but not in the “mental spotlight.”
Result: inattentional blindness

People honestly say “I never saw the gorilla.”
Drivers say “The motorcycle came out of nowhere.”
In both cases, the object was there — attention just never fully grabbed it.
I want to make sure the key idea is solid in your own words.

Very short answer, your version:

Why do psychologists say the Invisible Gorilla experiment proves inattentional blindness, not bad eyesight?

because thier mind was occupied with a task unrelaed to the missed event

Perfectly put. 🎯

Yes — their mind was occupied with a task unrelated to the missed event (counting passes), so attention filtered out the gorilla even though it was right there. That’s exactly inattentional blindness.

Before we wrap this lesson later, I want to connect one last thing: real□world safety.

Pick one you’d like to explore next:

A: Drivers missing pedestrians or cyclists
B: Phone use while walking
C: Eyewitnesses missing details during a crime
a

Great choice. 🚗🚶‍♂️

Think of a driver turning right on a busy street. Their main task is: “Find a gap in the cars so I can go.”

Step by step:

Their eyes receive the whole scene – cars, sidewalk, pedestrian about to cross.
Their attention spotlight is mostly on approaching cars.
A pedestrian steps off the curb. The driver might honestly say: “I didn’t see them.”

Psychology view:

The pedestrian was visible, but selective attention was tuned to cars, not people on the side.
This can lead to inattentional blindness for the pedestrian, just like the gorilla.
Quick check, super short answer:

In that right-turn example, what is the driver's attention mainly selecting for: pedestrians or cars?

Cars

Exactly — their attention is mainly locked onto cars, so pedestrians can become the "gorilla" in the scene. 🚗➡️🚶‍♂️

That's the real-world danger of selective attention:

The more tightly your mind focuses on one task, the more likely you are to miss other important things that are right in front of you.

I want to check that you can now explain this in a general way.

Very short, your own words:

What is inattentional blindness?

the failure to notice things going on around you that arent directly related to what your busy concentrating on

That's an excellent definition, Ron — that is inattentional blindness. 🎯

You've nailed the key outcome for this lesson:

You can explain inattentional blindness
You can connect it to the Invisible Gorilla experiment
And you can see how it matters in real life (like driving and pedestrians)
Quick recap in one line:

Our attention is limited, and when it's tightly focused on one task, we can completely miss other obvious things — even gorillas and people in front of us.

You're all set on this topic. ☑
When you're ready, you can move on to the next lesson in your General Psychology course, and I'll be here to walk through it with you step by step.